
The Decision Rulebook

Turn recurring approvals into standing rules your team can use without you.

WHY THIS EXISTS

Your team isn't asking for approval because they're unconfident. They're asking because they've never been given the framework to decide without you. The fix isn't handing tasks off, it's codifying the judgement you already carry in your head, so the decision doesn't need to reach your desk twice.

A decision rule does three things at once: it names when it applies, it states the threshold or criteria, and it says who decides. Written down, tested, and actually used, not filed away.

HOW TO USE THIS

1. **Identify the approval.** Pick something that has crossed your desk more than twice in the last month, where the outcome would usually have been the same whether you saw it or not.
 2. **Write the rule.** Use the template below. Be specific: a rule with no numbers in it isn't a rule, it's a suggestion.
 3. **Test it.** Hand the decision to the person who'll own it going forward. Watch what they do with it once, before you let go completely.
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THE TEMPLATE

Use one sheet per recurring approval. Three are set up below to get you started, add more as you find them.

Decision rule #1

What is the recurring approval?

Trigger: when does this rule apply?

Threshold or criteria: the number or condition that decides it

Who decides without you

What "good enough" looks like

Review date: when this rule gets checked and adjusted

Decision rule #2

What is the recurring approval?

Trigger: when does this rule apply?

Threshold or criteria: the number or condition that decides it

Who decides without you

What "good enough" looks like

Review date: when this rule gets checked and adjusted

Decision rule #3

What is the recurring approval?

Trigger: when does this rule apply?

Threshold or criteria: the number or condition that decides it

Who decides without you

What "good enough" looks like

Review date: when this rule gets checked and adjusted

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

A decision rule is working when the outcome stops needing to be reported to you as a decision, only as a summary. If people are still checking with you after the rule exists, the rule is either too vague, or nobody actually told them it existed.

This is the same discipline VOS tracks under Operations & Delivery: whether someone new could run your core process from written instructions alone. A decision rule is that discipline applied to judgement calls instead of tasks.

Ready to install this properly, across every part of the business, not just the approvals you happened to notice? [Take the free VOS trial](#) or [book a 30-minute strategy call](#).

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